

Glossary of Key Terms: Prototyping

Prototype

An early version of a product used to explore ideas, test designs, and gather feedback before full development.

Example: A draft version of an online shopping app.

Pivot

A significant change in a product or design direction based on feedback or new insights.

Example: Changing a project from a desktop application to a mobile app after user testing.

Fidelity

The degree to which a prototype resembles the final product.

Low Fidelity

Very rough and simple.

Example: Hand-drawn sketches.

Medium Fidelity

More detailed but still incomplete.

Example: Wireframes.

High Fidelity

Very realistic and close to the final product.

Example: Interactive app prototype with realistic visuals.

Low-Fidelity Prototype (Low-Fi Prototype)

A simple prototype created quickly and cheaply to explore ideas.

Example: Paper sketches of a website.

Paper Prototype

A prototype made from paper screens and interface elements.

Users interact with it while a person simulates system responses.

Medium-Fidelity Prototype

A more detailed prototype that focuses on structure and workflow but not final visual appearance.

Example: A wireframe created in Figma.

Wireframe

A simplified blueprint of an interface focusing on structure, layout, and navigation.

Characteristics:

- Usually grayscale
- Minimal graphics
- Focuses on organization

Computer Prototype

A software-based prototype that displays screens and supports limited user interaction.

Example: A clickable prototype in Figma.

Interactive Prototype

A prototype that allows users to click, navigate, and perform actions.

Example: A mobile app prototype with multiple linked screens.

High-Fidelity Prototype (Hi-Fi Prototype)

A prototype that closely resembles the final product in appearance and behavior.

Characteristics:

- Realistic layout
- Colors and graphics
- Interactive controls

Video Prototype

A video demonstrating how users would interact with a system and how it fits into a real-world context.

Example: A short video showing how a smart-home app might be used.

Wizard-of-Oz Prototype

A prototype in which some or all functionality is secretly performed by a human.

Example: A human generates chatbot responses while users think AI is responding.

Interface

The part of a system that allows communication between users and the system.

Widget

A user interface component that users interact with.

Examples:

- Button
- Checkbox
- Text field
- Dropdown menu

Screen Layout

The arrangement of interface elements on a screen.

Example: Deciding where menus, buttons, and content appear.

Dynamic Screen

A screen whose content changes in response to user actions.

Example: A shopping cart that updates automatically.

Navigation

The way users move through a system.

Examples:

- Menus
- Links
- Navigation bars

Scenario

A description of how a user might interact with a system in a particular situation.

Example: A student registering for courses online.

Storyboard

A sequence of illustrations showing how users interact with a system over time.

Example: A comic-strip style sequence showing a customer ordering food.

Task Flow

The detailed order of actions users perform to accomplish a goal.

Example: Open App → Add Product → Checkout.

MVP (Minimum Viable Product)

The simplest version of a product that includes only essential features.

Example: A ride-sharing app that allows booking rides but not scheduling future trips.

User Testing

Evaluating a design by observing real users perform tasks.

Think-Aloud Method

A testing technique in which users explain what they are thinking while performing tasks.

Example: "I'm clicking here because I expect to find Settings."

Facilitator

The person who conducts the usability test.

Responsibilities:

- Explain tasks
- Encourage thinking aloud
- Keep sessions focused

Observer

The person who watches the session and records observations.

Responsibilities:

- Take notes
- Identify usability problems
- Record user behavior

Wizard

The human operator in a Wizard-of-Oz prototype.

Example: A researcher manually provides responses that appear to come from the system.

Human-in-the-Loop

A design approach where a person performs tasks that would normally be automated.

Example: A human answering questions while pretending to be an AI assistant.

Back-End

The hidden part of a system that processes data and executes business logic.

Example: Verifying login credentials.

Back-Office Interface

A special interface used by operators to manage or support a prototype behind the scenes.

Example: The control panel used by the wizard in a Wizard-of-Oz prototype.